PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Ford Full-size Bronco

1978–1996 · 1978–79 · 1980–86 · 1987–91 · 1992–96

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Rust in Ford's favorite places**
  Bronco Zone's long-time checklist names the inner rear fender lips, the bottoms of the B-pillars and the bottom of the tailgate, where spot-welded seams trap moisture. Also check the radiator core support where it bolts to the frame (mostly the passenger side), the floor around the rear seat-belt mounts, rain gutters, body mounts and the frame itself.

- [ ] **Run the tailgate glass both ways**
  Lower and raise the rear window from the key and from the dash switch, then open and close the tailgate. Check the tailgate drains and the outer glass seal. A window that works from only one control points to the circuit, not the motor. On many trucks the driver's window switch must be in the center position before the tailgate key switch will work.

- [ ] **Read the tires before the TTB**
  Uneven inner or outer tread wear means camber trouble. Look at the radius-arm bushings, which perish (one Bronco Zone owner replaced his at 80,000 miles), and check the ball joints and tie-rod ends. If the truck is lifted, ask whether adjustable camber bushings were fitted, because Bronco Graveyard says even 1–2-inch lift springs normally need them.

- [ ] **E4OD fluid and the O/D light**
  On 1990–96 automatics, the fluid should be red, not brown or burnt-smelling, and read full at operating temperature. A flashing overdrive light (TCIL) while driving means the transmission has stored a fault code. Owners recommend fluid and filter service every 30,000 miles, and sooner for towing.

- [ ] **Try 4-High and 4-Low**
  On push-button trucks, the shift motor and its connector are known trouble spots, often from a broken travel stop or a fouled connector. Ford recalled some 1993 trucks (93V-089) whose transfer cases had the wrong shift motor and could slip out of 4-High.

- [ ] **Compression, cooling and leaks**
  Owners call a bad compression or vacuum test a deal-breaker. The plastic side seams of the radiator leak, most visibly after the engine cools overnight. Check the rear main and timing-cover seals, look for a cracked exhaust manifold or Y-pipe, and check for water in the oil.

- [ ] **Decide whether you need a removable top**
  1978–93 tops were designed to come off. From 1994 the top carries the rear three-point belts and the center brake light and is held with security Torx bolts. You can still remove it, but Wikipedia notes that driving without it can earn a ticket in some places.

- [ ] **Open recalls**
  Old trucks still show up with open campaigns. The 1994–96 speed-control deactivation switch (05V-388) and its 1993 equivalents (07V-336 and 08V-051) can overheat and burn, and 1988–91 trucks had an ignition-switch short-circuit recall (96V-071). Check the VIN on NHTSA's site.

RECALLS TO ASK ABOUT

- ☐ **Speed-control deactivation switch may overheat or burn**
  1994–1996 · NHTSA 05V-388
- ☐ **Speed-control deactivation switch (1993 trucks)**
  1993 · NHTSA 07V-336 · 08V-051
- ☐ **Ignition switch internal short circuit**
  1988–1991 · NHTSA 96V-071
- ☐ **Transfer case built with the wrong shift motor**
  1993 · NHTSA 93V-089
- ☐ **Parking-brake self-adjuster pawl slips**
  1992–1994 · NHTSA 94V-169
- ☐ **Front bumper U-clip nuts can fracture**
  1993–1994 · NHTSA 94V-018
- ☐ **Door latch release cable can freeze**
  1992 · NHTSA 92V-006
- ☐ **Spring-lock fuel-line coupling may not be engaged**
  1986–1987 · NHTSA 87V-139
- ☐ **Fuel-rail burrs may damage O-rings**
  1985 · NHTSA 84V-162
- ☐ **Steering-arm knuckles improperly manufactured**
  1979 · NHTSA 79V-035

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- ☐ **Solid axle or TTB**
  Only 1978–79 trucks have the solid, coil-sprung Dana 44 front axle; everything from 1980 has the Twin Traction Beam, an independent design with a U-joint in the middle and the differential offset to the driver's side. A 1980–96 truck on a solid axle has been converted.
- ☐ **Faces by year**
  1978 Customs had round headlights and Ranger XLTs rectangular ones, which became standard for 1979. 1980–81 trucks have F-O-R-D on the hood and 1982–86 trucks the blue oval. 1987–91 trucks have flush composite headlights, and 1992–96 trucks a rounder nose with a larger grille. Turn signals in the mirrors mean 1996.
- ☐ **Silver Anniversary Edition**
  1991 only. Currant Red paint was exclusive to the package and came with a gray leather interior, the first leather in a Bronco. Like the Nite and Eddie Bauer, it came only with a V8 and an automatic.
- ☐ **Free Wheelin' and Nite**
  Free Wheelin' (1978–79, Custom or Ranger XLT) was a cosmetic package with tricolor stripes and blacked-out trim. Nite (1991–92) was blacked out with contrasting graphics.
- ☐ **Four doors**
  Ford never built a four-door 1978–96 Bronco. A four-door is a Centurion Classic C-150 or C-350, an F-Series crew cab joined to a Bronco rear body on a 140-in wheelbase.

NOTES

From the full guide at https://boxytrucks.com/models/bronco/full-size/, with sources. Recalls follow the VIN: check at nhtsa.gov/recalls. General information only, not a professional inspection; see boxytrucks.com/about/disclaimer/. © BoxyTrucks